

means of diminishing the amount and the cost of the military establishments.”

The British administration saw railways as a practical means of receiving intelligence inputs from and sending instructions to even the most remote parts of the country. It would bring immediate, immeasurable advantages while repelling hostile attacks by stationing troops in far-off regions. A firm system of internal communications was even more imperative, considering that it was only a few British men, who were trying to control a vast geographical territory, outnumbered by a huge native population.

The Industrial Revolution (1750–1830) changed the economic policy Britain adopted towards India. Till then, India had remained a colony primarily as a source of land revenue and luxury goods. However, with industrialization and the loss of Britain's American colonies, it became a source of raw materials and a market for finished products as well. For instance, cotton, which grew in abundance in India, appeared lucrative for supporting the textile mills in Lancashire and Manchester. With railways, cotton could be transported easily from plains to ports. Similarly, factory-produced goods from Britain could find new markets in distant locales. At the same time, the British administration also felt that railways would bring social changes in the country and unify it as a political whole, even though scepticism about its acceptance by the native population lingered in the background.